

EYEWITNESS July 13-16, 1863

Riots in New York

Civil War battlefields were not the only places where violence and death occurred in the 1860s. From July 13-16, 1863, rioters stormed the streets of New York City when a shortage in military recruits led Congress to pass the North's first conscription act. Violence erupted over a clause that allowed wealthy men to pay a \$300.00 commutation fee to avoid military service.

"The draft began on Saturday, the twelfth, very foolishly ordered by the government, who supposed that these Union victories would make the people willing to submit ... by Monday morning there were large crowds assembled to resist the draft. All day yesterday there were dreadful scenes enacted in the city. The police were successfully opposed; many were killed, many houses gutted and burned: the colored asylum was burned and all the furniture carried off by women: Negroes were hung in the streets! All last night the fire-bells rang, but at last, in God's good mercy, the rain came down in torrents and scattered the crowds, giving the city authorities time to organize ... I did not wonder at the spirit in which the poor resented the three-hundred-dollar clause."

DIARY OF MARIA LYDIG, A "UNION LADY" MARRIED TO A NEW YORK JUDGE

"I stepped to the window and saw a light in the sky ... others joined me in viewing the wanton destruction of property by the infuriated mob ... while I was wondering at the doings of the infuriated people, a drunken man passed along the street and what he might say in such a condition would speak the sentiments of the mob. He said that 'a poor man had to be drafted and go to the war, but a rich man could pay his money and stay at home. That's what's the matter.' This is the sentiment that lies at the foundation of the whole trouble as far as the rioters are concerned ... more than thirty have been brought in injured by clubs and fire arms. Men, women, and children have been wounded by gun shots, so eager have they been to see the fray ... some will get well and others will die. They all say they were not participants but merely